

reflective of a bleaker mental state.

In 1936, Poulenc visited the beautiful French pilgrimage site of Rocamadour, and rediscovered his Catholic faith. This prompted a series of religious works, beginning with the *Litanies à la Vierge Noire de Rocamadour* and the *Mass in G major*.

After World War II, Poulenc found success as a pianist and accompanist, but his compositions were thought by the avant-garde to be conventional and lightweight; even the profound *Stabat Mater* and dark operas such as *La Voix humaine* and *Dialogues des Carmélites*—which tells the story of Carmelite nuns who were guillotined at the end of the French Revolution for refusing to renounce their calling—did not receive the serious attention they deserved until the 21st century.